

**Rick and Morty: An Absurd Show About Absurdity and the
Meaning of Life**

by

Erica Huang

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Rick and Morty is an adult cartoon created by Justin Roiland and Dan Harmon, starring Rick Sanchez, the smartest man in the universe, and the inventor of interdimensional time travel. While *Rick and Morty* is raunchy, funny, and unserious at times, it also addresses deeper topics such as nihilism, absurdism, and the meaning of life. The paper's goal is to convince readers to watch *Rick and Morty* because it not only provides many laughs, but also thought-provoking questions and circumstances.

Nihilists believe that our existence is fundamentally meaningless and reject objective truth, moral truth, and the value of life (The Ethics Centre). Absurdism is less of a moral philosophy and more of a view that recognizes the conflict between humans' innate desire for meaning in a meaningless world.

Rick is the personification of nihilism. He is the inventor of interdimensional travel, meaning he can travel to any universe, like a universe where he made one decision instead of the other. If he messes up in one world, he can just go to another and start new, making him believe that life has no inherent meaning. It is difficult for him to form close relationships with those around him because he knows that there is always another one of them in another universe. However, he still shows love and care for his family, sometimes sacrificing himself for them. Despite his nihilistic tendencies, Rick can't help but be human, demonstrating the true absurdity of life.

One especially thought-provoking episode is season 2 episode 6, "The Ricks Must be Crazy." In this episode, Rick creates a universe inside a box, and the purpose of the inhabitants' lives is to generate power for Rick's space car. However, they think of Rick as a god who gave them access to electricity. A scientist named Zeep in Rick's "microverse" then does the same thing, so his people no longer have to generate electricity— instead, the people inside Zeep's "miniverse" can generate electricity to power Zeep's universe, which was created to power Rick's car. This provokes the question, "Do the lives of the inhabitants of the miniverse and microverse matter?" This episode displays both nihilism and absurdism. An inhabitant of the miniverse ends up killing himself because he missed his father's funeral to work on an important project, only to nihilistically realize that nothing matters. What makes it absurd is that we have no idea how many layers down this goes. Rick and Morty could be inside of yet another universe fabricated for a certain purpose. Despite this unknown, people every day still search for meaning in their lives.

Rick and Morty does a great job of adding humor to otherwise dark and heavy topics, making it more digestible to viewers. I think this show is perfect for laughs, pondering existence, and everything in between. More specifically, I think Generation Z would enjoy this show as we have grown up expressing ourselves through dark humor, which is exactly what the show does.

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CHARACTERS AND DEFINITIONS

Characters

Beth Smith (“Real Beth” and “Space Beth”)	Rick’s daughter. Rick makes a clone of Beth but mixes them up, so he doesn’t know which is the real Beth and which is the cloned Beth. One of them stayed on Earth (“Real Beth”) and one of them went out to space (“Space Beth”). It was never revealed who is real and who is the clone.
Butter Robot	Sentient robot Rick created for the sole purpose of passing the butter
Kyle	Inhabitant of Zeep Xanflorp’s “miniverse,” a fabricated universe inside a box
Morty Smith	Rick’s grandson. Accompanies Rick on all of his adventures.
Rick Sanchez (C-137)	Smartest man in the universe and main character. Internal battle between knowing nothing matters and still caring for his family. “Nihilist” but also demonstrates absurdism. “C-137” refers to the dimension he is from.
Rick Sanchez (Prime)	The main antagonist of the show. Killed Rick’s wife, Diane, in all dimensions. “Prime” refers to the dimension he is from.
Zeep Xanflorp	Inhabitant of Rick’s “microverse,” a fabricated universe inside a box

Other Definitions

Interdimensional travel	The term for going to different dimensions. Rick can do this using his portal gun
Microverse	The fabricated universe Rick creates in season 2 episode 6. It contains a planet with sentient life.
Miniverse	The fabricated universe Zeep Xanflorp creates in season 2 episode 6. It contains a planet with sentient life.
Portal Gun	Rick’s device that allows him to travel to any dimension by shooting a portal that he can walk through

1.0 INTRODUCTION AND CONTEXT

What is the meaning of life? Is there a meaning to life? Does it even matter? These are just some of the mind-numbing questions touched upon by *Rick and Morty*, a cartoon by Justin Roiland and Dan Harmon starring Rick Sanchez, the smartest man in the universe and the inventor of interdimensional time travel. This paper will dive into the philosophies of nihilism and absurdism using plots, episodes, and characters from *Rick and Morty*. This paper's goal is to convince readers that *Rick and Morty* is a show worth watching, not just because it is full of laughs, but because it introduces deep and important topics in a very palatable way.

Rick has seen the horrors of an infinite universe and infinite universes. However, there is one thing that haunts him more than anything else. In season 7 episode 5, "Unmortricken," we learn that the Rick we follow, from dimension C-137, was approached by Rick Prime, a Rick from dimension Prime. Rick Prime offered Rick C-137 the technology for interdimensional travel. When Rick C-137 refused, wanting to invent it for himself, Rick Prime killed his wife, Diane. Not just in dimension C-137, but in all dimensions where a Rick exists (Rick and Morty Fandom). This made Rick C-137 the only version of himself, apart from Rick Prime, to invent interdimensional time travel, as he wanted to seek out Rick Prime for revenge.

2.0 NIHILISM AND ABSURDISM

Now I will discuss nihilism and absurdism, and how they differ from each other. Nihilists believe that our existence is fundamentally meaningless and reject objective truth, moral truth, and the value of life (The Ethics Centre). As Rick's character demonstrates throughout the show, nihilism can be both haunting and freeing, depending on how you look at it. In season 2 episode

2, “A Mortynight Run,” Rick sells a weapon to an assassin in exchange for tokens to be used at an arcade. Morty is upset by Rick’s immoral decision, claiming that “selling someone the gun is the same as pulling the trigger,” to which Rick replies, “No, it’s the same as doing nothing” (“A Mortynight Run” season 2 episode 2). This shows the more freeing side of Rick’s nihilistic views, as he doesn’t feel constrained by moral principles. The more haunted side of Rick appears through motifs, such as his drinking problem and his constant rudeness towards his family.

Absurdism is less of a moral philosophy and more of a view that recognizes the conflict between humans’ innate desire for meaning in a meaningless world. For example, Rick knows that nothing matters and rejects the existence of a higher being. However, in season 2 episode 1, “A Rickle in Time,” Rick looks death in the eye, prays to God, and says goodbye to his family. His survival instincts kicked in, telling him that he had something to live for and that life matters. The show does a great job of conveying this perspective in multiple ways discussed later in this paper.

3.0 BUTTER ROBOT (character)

A scene that captures nihilism very well is the introduction to season 1 episode 9, “Something Ricked This Way Comes,” when Rick creates a self-aware robot for the sole purpose of passing butter. This scene takes only about a minute, showing how, as the butter robot’s creator, Rick doesn’t give it a second thought and brings the robot into existence just because. However, right when the butter robot is booted up, it immediately asks, “What is my purpose?” to which Rick responds, “You pass butter.” The scene ends with the butter robot looking down at its hands and saying, “Oh my god,” to which Rick responds with “Yeah, welcome to the club, pal.” The scene being so short adds to the comical feeling it conveys, because it makes it feel like an unimportant scene with no meaning and just for laughs. However, it also displays Rick’s nihilistic

perspective. He knows that life has no meaning, and thus doesn't have much respect for others' lives. When the robot says "Oh my god," it's realizing that there's nothing more to its life, which is something that Rick already knows. The only difference is that Rick couldn't care less, and it seems like the robot couldn't care more.

4.0 "THE RICKS MUST BE CRAZY" (season 2 episode 6)

An episode that deserves its own space for discussing nihilism is season 2 episode 6: "The Ricks Must be Crazy." Rick, his grandson Morty, and his granddaughter Summer are about to drive their space car when Rick notices that the battery isn't generating any power. To figure out what the issue is, Rick and Morty travel inside the battery, which is actually a universe created inside a box and contains a planet of aliens. Rick built this "microverse" and introduced the aliens to a "gooble box," a device that requires the aliens' physical exertion to generate power for their society. However, what they don't know is that a portion of that generated energy is going into powering Rick's space car. Essentially, the aliens exist for the sole purpose of generating energy for Rick. Once inside the microverse, Rick discovers that one of the aliens, Zeep Xanflorp, created a "miniverse" to take over generating power for them, the same thing Rick did to the aliens. In the end, the inhabitants of the miniverse and the aliens of the microverse realize that the reason for their existence is to generate power. However, if they refuse to generate power, then Rick can easily throw away the "broken" battery and start from scratch.

"The Ricks Must Be Crazy" is very similar to *The Matrix* by Lana Wachowski and Lilly Wachowski because it is about a reality inside a reality, and makes one question if maybe we are in a matrix ourselves. Like Rick's microverse, the matrix in *The Matrix* was created to generate power for the apex intelligence, in this case, AI-powered robots. The one difference is that the

inhabitants in the microverse are required to do something (generate power using the gooble box), whereas the humans in the matrix just have to live out “normal” lives. One question brought up by these two instances is: “Do the inhabitants of the microverse and the matrix have meaningful lives?”

To start, let's define the difference between meaning in life and meaning of life. Meaning “in” life is “where a human person is what can exhibit meaning,” and the meaning “of” life is “where the human species as a whole is what can be meaningful or not” (Metz). The meaning of life for the aliens in Rick’s microverse and the Matrix is to generate power. However, within each, each inhabitant has the agency to define their own meaning in life. In the microverse, Zeep Xanflorp created his own meaning in life by becoming a scientist and inventing the miniverse that makes gooble boxes obsolete. Since the inhabitants can still have meaning *in* their lives, I do think that their lives are meaningful. The next question is, “Does it even matter whether there is a meaning of life or not?” For humans, I would argue that it doesn’t matter as long as we feel like we have meaning. Reality is built on our perception of the world, so as long as we perceive meaning, it is reality. This can also be applied to Rick’s microverse. The aliens who reside in it build their reality on their perception of their own universe. And, like us, I would assume that they are unable to perceive what exists beyond their universe. In this way, it doesn’t really matter why they exist.

5.0 SPACE BETH VS REAL BETH (plot)

A story arc I would like to analyze is the Beth and Space Beth arc. At the end of season 3 in “The ABC’s of Beth,” Beth realizes that, as much as she may hate it, she is very similar to Rick, which makes her wonder if she is wasting her life on Earth. As a result, Rick gives Beth a

choice: she can stay on Earth and continue living life as normal, or Rick can make an exact clone of her to take over her place while she goes out and experiences the multiverse. The season ends on a cliffhanger, and we don't find out what she chose until the end of season 4 in "Star Mort Rickturn of the Jedi," when we discover that she made Rick choose. She tells Rick, "For once in my life, I want you to decide, Dad. Do you want me to stay here and be part of your life, or do you want me to leave?" ("Star Mort Rickturn of the Jedi" season 4 episode 10). At the end of the episode, we find out that Rick created an exact clone of Beth, put both real and clone Beth into their own vats, and mixed up the vats so he didn't know which was which. He then randomly sent one of the Beths out to space and erased his memory of creating the clone, thus escaping the emotional turmoil of his actions.

I think this is one of the best story arcs for discussing philosophical ideas because it deals with the self, relationships, and the meaning of one's life. One of the biggest questions from this arc is "Who is the real Beth?" The show purposefully doesn't reveal which is which to give the viewer something to think about. I can't help but wonder if it even matters who is who. On one hand, "Because they would essentially be facsimiles of the original person, there is concern that the clones might possess less moral worth" (Manninen). Even if clone Beth has the same memories as real Beth, that doesn't mean she lived those memories. In that case, I would say that clone Beth is not the same as real Beth, and side with Manninen. On the other hand, reality is all about perception, so if clone Beth truly feels like she lived those memories, then how is that any different than real people recalling memories? The only perception we have of the past and how we got to the present is through memories. In this case, I side with those who believe that it doesn't matter and they are both equally moral beings. I can't decide what I believe about this topic, as I think there are equally strong arguments for either side.

Now let's talk about Rick's relationship with Beth. In this story arc, it is clear that Rick is desperate for emotional detachment from Beth as he is unable to make and deal with an emotional decision. This comes from his nihilistic worldview, where nothing matters, and therefore, connections with people don't matter either. Because of this meaninglessness, the complexity of relationships and family is unnecessarily complicated to maintain. But then why wouldn't Rick just tell Beth that he doesn't care? Why would he go through all the trouble to forget what he did? At the end of the day, despite his nihilism, Rick is still a human being, meaning that he still inherently cares for his family. He cares for Beth and wants her to explore the universe. But he also wants her here with him. In the end, like always, he tries to escape his emotions to avoid falling into the absurdity of life.

6.0 IS RICK TRULY A NIHILIST?

Rick Sanchez, having access to infinite universes and therefore evidence that nothing is special, appears to be the most nihilistic of them all. He claims that "love is just a chemical reaction that compels animals to breed" (season 1 episode 6). When a sentient robot he built realized that its sole purpose is to pass butter, making its life essentially meaningless, all Rick said was "Yeah, welcome to the club, pal" ("Something Ricked This Way Comes" season 1 episode 9). He rejects the existence of God, engages in purges for fun, and turns himself into a pickle to avoid family therapy.

Despite all of this, Rick cares deeply for his family, making fans wonder if he really is a nihilist. At the end of "A Rickle in Time," Rick sacrifices himself to save Morty, saying, "I'm ok with this. Be good Morty. Be better than me" ("A Rickle in Time" season 2 episode 1). He then starts praying to God to save him and let him live. When given the choice to make Beth stay or

leave, he was so conflicted with his caring for her and his knowledge that nothing matters, that he couldn't make a decision and ended up hurting both of them. No matter how bad he doesn't want to, Rick cares deeply for his friends and family.

So is he truly a nihilist? I don't think anyone can truly be a nihilist, but Rick is as nihilistic as you can humanely get. It's in our nature to care for our family and friends, and no amount of knowledge can require that. This is why our lives are absurd, and why Rick is a great example of it. As much as he knows that nothing in life matters, he can't fight his instinct to save his family. Ultimately, I would call Rick a nihilist, but it's important to acknowledge that no one can be truly nihilistic due to our human nature.

7.0 WHY WATCH RICK AND MORTY?

Feeling sad and wanting a good laugh? Watch *Rick and Morty*. Feeling existential and wanting to think about why we're here and if it even matters? Watch *Rick and Morty*. Feeling nothing? Watch *Rick and Morty*. The show's ability to address deep topics with dark humor and mix it with the silliest ideas makes it a truly dynamic show for any viewer, and allows them to get out what they put into it.

I started watching *Rick and Morty* because I wanted a mindless show that I could get lots of laughs out of, and that's exactly what I got the first time I watched it. However, during the second time, I started to wonder if there was anything more to the show. I looked through the Fandom and realized there was a whole other dimension to *Rick and Morty* that I had completely missed the first time, full of opinions on philosophy, family, and general life. By the end of my second time watching it, I became a frequent visitor of the Fandom, reading theories about each episode I watched, and making notes of my observations. The third time, I noticed more, and the

fourth time, I noticed even more. This show never gets old because it doesn't give you everything all at once. It's kind of like poetry—the first time reading a poem, you look at the structure, the title, and the words at a superficial level. Only when you read it through a second or third time do you truly start to understand the semantics hidden behind the punctuation, the line breaks, and the word choice.

Whenever someone asks me to recommend a show, *Rick and Morty* is always what comes to mind first. As I have shown throughout the paper, it is a palatable resource for learning about life's greatest questions. If you are anything like me and other fans of *Rick and Morty* in that you enjoy the humor in life, but also can get caught in the absurdity, this show is for you.

8.0 MY PHILOSOPHICAL VIEWS AND OPINIONS

My philosophy is that there is no one philosophy. Whatever belief makes life bearable is the belief you should follow. If that's believing that we have a purpose in life, or that we don't, then by all means, go for it. No physical evidence exists for either claim, and I don't think we will ever find evidence. The only way we would figure this out is if we were omniscient and omnipotent, which is way out of our scope as human beings. The best thing we can do is guess. But this doesn't mean that we now have a pass to live life without respect or kindness for others. The way we feel and the reality we make for ourselves are facts, and the existence of you and those around you is a fact. Beliefs should not determine how you treat others. It should only determine how you view the world and how you live your personal life.

I believe that there is no meaning to our lives, that we are here purely by chance, and that God doesn't exist. But I believe that we have the power to create meaning *in* our lives, and that that is enough. If I had to put a label on what my belief is, I would say I am an existentialist,

someone who believes that our lives are inherently meaningless, but we have the power to create our meaning (The Ethics Centre). We don't need a bigger purpose in the universe, as long as we have purpose within our perceptual reality. I feel purpose when I feel joy from studying something I love, and hugging my friends and family. I feel purpose when I am sad, scared, or angry. Our reality is what we perceive and what we feel. Purpose comes from these same roots.

9.0 CONCLUSION

Rick and Morty is a show worth watching, not just because it is full of witty humor, but because it also addresses important philosophical topics. Two schools of thought touched upon by the show are nihilism and absurdism, mostly shown through Rick's character. He lives life carelessly at times due to his nihilism, but when dealing with his family, like his daughter Beth, he can't help but feel conflicted between his knowledge that nothing matters and his apparent love for them. In the end, I think Rick is a nihilist as much as a human can be a nihilist, but the fact that no one can be truly nihilist makes our lives absurd.

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